

SAURABH SINGH



Arabian Nights

A clever, tongue-in-cheek tale of desire and friendship in the lives of young women in a non-permissive society

GIRLS OF RIYADH

by RAJAA ALSANEA

Penguin

Price: £11.99

Pages: 300

■ **By Urvashi Butalia**

Riyadh, Saudi Arabia. Four young, wealthy women get on with their lives. They party, they sing, dance when they can (mostly at weddings and engagement ceremonies), they fall in love, marry, are divorced, abandoned, belittled, their hearts break, their spirit survives, and they dream, and dream, and dream... Their story comes to us in this wonderful, somewhat tongue-in-cheek, somewhat serious, somewhat irreverent, but totally above-reproach tale of love and desire in the city.

Meet Gamrah, whose wedding sets

the scene for the story; Mashael, otherwise known as Michelle, the most "westernised" of the four, who has studied in America and speaks English better than Arabic; Lamees, whose family is from Jeddah; and Sadeem, petite, more beautiful than the bride and endowed with "talent" (in other words ample breasts and behind). Between them they've studied business management, medicine, computer science and history; one has worked as a wedding planner, another has chosen to leave her studies and get married. Each of them dreams of love and marriage, a handsome groom, a sensitive husband.

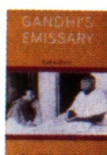
But life intervenes, and the package is always lacking in something or the other. While Gamrah holds on to her mother's advice not to give herself to her husband too soon, she finds that time stretches on until she is forced to

take the initiative. Not surprisingly, the seemingly bashful groom has a lover stashed away somewhere. Meanwhile Sadeem's marriage never takes off, after a night when she allows her husband to go "too far".

But this isn't a gloomy tale. It's lively, fun, and totally subversive, while pretending to be otherwise. Much of the fun of it lies in the telling. The narrator, whose identity is the subject of speculation and who guards it jealously throughout, runs a Yahoo group. Every Friday she (for we assume it's a she) sends out a mail to the ever-growing list of people, that takes the story of the four friends forward. Soon, responses pour in. They carry anger, predictably from fundamentalist, conservative men who harangue her for allowing her women too much freedom; appreciation, usually from other young women; questions—is she one of the four, how come she knows their lives so intimately; and suggestions. Our narrator responds to some, ignores others, mostly makes fun of them. Why has she painted all men so badly? To her, they're like crocodiles, and she doesn't know much about crocodiles. But she does know her friends, and so they get the benefit of detailed authorial treatment.

This is a book that will make you laugh and gasp at the audacity of the commentary, at its cleverness in couching itself in just the right respectful language. This is a tale about love and sex in the lives of young women (and sometimes men) in a non-permissive society, about how girls in Saudi society look out for each other and negotiate the spaces available to them. Not only is it about female friendships and how women love and lose and mourn and celebrate, but it's also funny and sad and clever and naughty and eminently readable. ■

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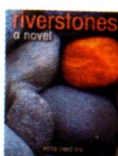
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